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Everyday narratives: CEO rhetoric on Twitter

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Abstract

Purpose – This paper investigates the everyday CEO communication in social media, with particular focus on Twitter. The purpose of this paper is to contribute with insights into how expectations on corporate leaders to be present in social media are translated into everyday communication practice and thereby add to literature on narrative leadership.

Design/methodology/approach – A content analysis of the Twitter feed of Håkan Nygren, the CEO of the Swedish digital bank Nordnet. In order to answer the question – what are the stories and the rhetoric of a CEO in the banking sector an ordinary day? – the data set covers the totality of tweets by Nygren from 10 April 2013 to 31 December 2015.

Findings – The everyday Twitter narrative of Nyberg challenges established ideas of social media about personalised tone and interactions by highlighting three characteristics: limited scope of actors and content including the local Nordnet sphere, a formal tone in the tweets mainly based on corporate information and presentation, and few examples of dialogue and a limited number of voices outside of Nordnet. The data set of Nyberg's Twitter feed during a period without any major events or crises for Nordnet paints a picture of a rather non-personal CEO with limited ideas on his mind to share online and with few friends.

Originality/value – Studies on social media and corporate communication have largely focussed on organisational crises. This study focuses on everyday narratives of managers and proves that the role of social media must be interpreted more broadly and as playing multiple roles, and that these roles are changing due to time and situation.

Keywords Leadership, Twitter, Rhetoric, CEO communication, Corporate narratives

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

One of the key skills highlighted among CEOs is the ability to be communicative – to manage the media and reach out to target groups. In a survey from IBM it is even argued that "if you don't have a social CEO, you're going to be less competitive" (Fidelman, 2012); a statement that emphasises the changing conditions for communication that are emerging with new technology. A similar survey offered by the social media branding firm BRAND fog shows, according to Alghawi *et al.* (2014, p. 184), that a majority of the employee respondents in the USA and UK "believe that CEO engagement on social media helps to communicate company values and shapes a company's brand reputation". Over the last few decades, storytelling and other narrative skills and techniques have been put forward as tools for successful leadership. In the popular management literature there are plenty of examples such as The Springboard: How Storytelling Ignites Action in Knowledge-era Organizations by Stephen Dennings (2001) and Leadership Storytelling by Jack Harris and Kim Barnes (2006).

From a scholarly perspective there has been an interest for some time now on organisational narratives, with forerunners such as Boje (1991) and Czarniawska (1997). Current research

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shows that narratives drive organisational change (Brown *et al.*, 2009) and construct identity (Whittle *et al.*, 2009). The narratives of leaders can be seen as a way to both construct and deconstruct leadership as well as a way to initiate and drive change. Backer (2008) shows, for example, how managers at Shell engaged in "narrative battles" with co-workers and external stakeholders to change the identity from an oil company to an energy company selling renewable energy. The specific character and role of storytelling for leaders and how leaders might use narratives in their work have however received rather scarce attention from scholars in management and organisation studies. This paper draws on storytelling literature in organisation theory together with ideas of narrative leadership – an area that is yet not largely explored (Auvinen *et al.*, 2013) – as well as from the emerging field of rhetoric as part of management and leadership practice and research (Bonet, 2014). The rhetorical focus brings persuasive and influential aspects to narratives of the organisation and leaders.

The expectations on CEOs to use narrative strategies and well-developed influential rhetoric are significant. Such expectations expand even further with digitisation, which brings an even expectations expand even further as it brings an even stronger focus on communication and offers both possibilities and challenges for CEOs and their communication efforts. In this paper, our purpose is to shed light on how such expectations are translated into everyday and constantly on-going CEO communication in social media and to contribute with insights on what role CEO rhetoric online may play.

With changing conditions for storytelling online, new forms of meaning creation concerning leadership are emerging. Similar to social media research and organisation studies in general (e.g. Shari *et al.*, 2011; van der Meer and Verhoeven, 2013), scholarly attention to leadership in relation to new media has to a large extent dealt with organisational crises (Schultz *et al.*, 2011; Utz *et al.*, 2013). Schultz *et al.* (2011) state that social media participate in and are used both in constructing crises as well as for actors to deconstruct crises. For example, Gruber *et al.* (2015) show the role of Twitter as a source of real-time news and information and thus a possible platform both for crises to spur and grow and for leaders to be active on and use when being criticised. Another example is provided by De Bussy and Paterson (2012) in their study on the commentary by the Australian Premier Anna Bligh and Prime Minister Julia Gillard during the Queensland floods in January 2011. De Bussy and Paterson show that as Twitter channels the "public mood in real time" and thus sets the agenda concerning, for example, how political leaders react to tweets by the public, the traditional agenda-setting model tends to function reversely: selection and framing of journalists set the public agenda. Despite the focus on digital storytelling in the contexts of organisational crisis, the use of social media as part of CEO communication increasingly comes with expectations of a more daily presence. In this paper the focus is therefore on the less empirically investigated area of everyday narratives online.

The study is an in-depth analysis of the CEO of the digital bank Nordnet, Håkan Nygren's, presence on Twitter. What are the stories and the rhetoric of a CEO in the banking sector on an ordinary day? The data is made up of the Nygren's Twitter feed and covers the period of 10 April 2013 to 31 December 2015. The data set includes more than two and a half years of the everyday life of a CEO in the banking sector. There were no organisational crises or any other major, radical events during period of study. Unlike the common characteristics of social media such as providing a space for personal communication and being a platform for dialogues and, not the least, a tool for deconstructing organisational crises, our findings picture a rather formal CEO with an almost total lack total lack of interaction with other Twitter users, and who is heavily dependent on a broader meta-narrative of the entire company.

Literature review: corporate narratives in a digital age

In the digitised media landscape, Twitter stands out as one of the most powerful platforms for communication between organisations and their stakeholders (Alexander and Gentry, 2014)

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and is described as "a real-time global newswire for individuals and organizations" (Gruber *et al.*, 2015, p. 168). Journalists and communication professionals have been singled out as key groups that are particularly active on Twitter (e.g. Russell *et al.*, 2015). Increasingly other groups, not the least various leaders, are using it as a platform for reaching out and engaging in dialogue.

With digital media, the meaning creation processes in the public sphere and on the media arena change. Increasingly we hear about "digital storytelling" as a particular kind of communication and online a new type of story is emerging; stories that allow people to shape and share images of themselves (Lundby, 2008a, p. 363). Much of the scholarly focus on what this new technology brings has been on the very personal story and on "self-representations" of individuals online (e.g. Couldry, 2008; Lundby, 2008a): "Amateur personal stories, focusing on 'me', flourish on social networking sites on the web and in digital storytelling workshops" (Lundby, 2008b, p. 1). The definition of "digital storytelling" is often also based on the "classic" form of personal stories, suggesting that these stories are now being told in public form using digital media resources (see e.g. definition by the Center for Digital Storytelling in California, www.storycenter.org). Lundby (2014, p. 21) frames digital storytelling as a "social and culture activity" that becomes "mediatized" as it turns digital – just as it would do regardless of media type. The digital setting however creates certain traits such as the multimodal capacity of storytelling online. Lundby explains that digitisation "expands the multimodal space" as it allows new combinations of text, music, visuals, and graphics.

In a study on corporate apologies on Twitter, Page (2014) shows in practice how the conversational possibilities are extended online in the emerging social media landscape. She states that while previous dyadic interactions took place in "in private", often through e-mail or over the telephone, Twitter and other social media channels allow the same conversations to be "publically mediated" and overheard by the wider general public. In this way, new forms of social participation through digital storytelling suggest a closer relationship between the public or "readers" and the producers and, also, allow roles to be switched (Lundby, 2008b). Jameson (2014) provides partly similar insights on how social media redraw boundaries for CEO communication. The company Chiquita Brands International considered to relocating its headquarters, which created a time of turmoil. Both proponents and opponents used Twitter as a channel to push their own opinions directly towards the CEO. Jameson's analysis illustrates how some of the CEO's previously private communication became public, some personal communication became professional, and how some professional communication became personal. Thus, microblogging changed the previous norms and guidelines for CEO communication and established new ones. Similarly, Lundby (2008a, p. 369) argues that "digital storytelling not only bypasses set forms of authority, but also invites new forms".

Digital narratives also simplify and stress collaborative processes in which the narrative of one organisation is made up of multiple narratives and these narratives are created in connection to one another. For example, Tunby Gulbrandsen and Nörholm Just (2013) show in their study of the Danish pharmaceutical company Novo Nordisk how different, even contradictory, narratives about the organisation were constructed and together made up a "meta-narrative". Thus, narratives about organisations are made through online collaborations – through many "micro-narratives". Whereas much research has paid attention to the specific character of storytelling online as being personal and micro-oriented, Tunby Gulbrandsen and Nörholm Just (2013) suggest that these micro-stories together create broader, more macro-oriented narratives. This is similar to the thoughts of Boyd and Waymer (2011) on organisational rhetoric, which can be seen as fostering many voices and interests.

This paper builds on the growing number of studies on the creation and conditions for leadership in relation to social media and in particular to Twitter. Focus is on the everyday

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and mundane narratives of the CEO; narratives created on a daily basis, online with 140 characters, at the time and during a period free from any major crises or any other significant, radical events.

Method and data

In order to understand the everyday social media narrative of a CEO, we searched for someone that we could expect to be representative for the emerging generation of "social" CEOs, as framed in the introductory paragraph. Håkan Nygren is CEO at one of the most digital banks in Sweden; a bank that is not only challenging established norms and rules on how to conduct banking business and what kinds of services are suitable, but is also enthusiastically using what the digital age brings in terms of communication possibilities. Nordnet is a fully-fledged news producer and provider online and as Nyberg himself states when entering the Twitter world and setting up a Twitter account: a digital company needs a digital CEO.

Nyberg was therefore a suitable CEO to select for our in-depth analysis of what narratives emerge in everyday tweets. Included in the analysis is the totality of tweets by Nordnet's CEO Håkan Nyberg during 10 April 2013 to 31 December 2015. The total number of tweets coded and analysed is 981. At the time, November 2015, Nyberg had 1,599 followers and was himself following 334 other Twitter users. About two-thirds of the tweets were re-tweets (tweets originally written by someone else on Twitter, but reposted by Nyberg) and 298 were Nyberg's own.

The first step was to download the totality of tweets (including re-tweets) from Nyberg's Twitter feed into the software programme NVivo. Second, in order to develop a first overarching understanding of the content – to get a "feeling" for Nyberg's tweets, we used the NVivo query tool. Based on pre-defined factors – such as #hashtags, and @mentions – we could develop a first brief understanding for what kinds of themes, in terms of used #hashtags were most frequently mentioned and who appeared to be Nyberg's "friends" in terms of who Nyberg re-tweeted and mentioned most often. Third, we discussed the first, automatically generated descriptive statistics over Nyberg's feed and developed pre-defined coding categories to use when analysing the Twitter feeds by coding the material in NVivo manually. The #hashtags were used as a first way of categorisation even though we realised early in the process that these would only give an understanding for a minor part of the number of tweets (646 tweets had no #hashtags). The first list of possible categories for coding included six broad ones: services (the core business of the bank), character of the tweet, dialogue with other Twitter users, happy/unhappy customers, leadership, social media, and the role of Twitter – as phenomenon in the corporate world and from a leadership perspective, and other types of publicity (e.g. newspaper interview). Some of the categories also had sub-categories.

Fourth, based on the initial, broad pre-defined categories, one of the researchers read all the tweets and coded them manually in NVivo. The categories were updated and adapted along the way the categories were updated and adapted in relation to the content of the tweets. Several new categories were added to the list along the way. Since NVivo allows us to be eclectic, the final list of categories (one tweet was often coded for several categories) included as many as 64 categories. Finally, as a fifth step, the two researchers discussed thoroughly the content of the Twitter feed in relation to the categories that had been developed during the coding process. Many of the categories could based on frequency and topic many of the categories could be merged into larger, broader categories. The two authors jointly discussed possible mergers of the tweets and developed three very broad categories that give a comprehensive understanding for Nyberg's overall Twitter feed of Nyberg: marketing and circulating Nordnet content already published elsewhere, status updates from meetings, and leadership and diversity management.

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Research setting: Nordnet – digital bank and news producer

Nordnet has business in Sweden, Norway, Denmark and Finland and calls itself a "digital bank" that particularly values innovation (Nordnet, 2016). The bank states on the website that it was founded 1996 as "a reaction to the outdated structures in the banking business". As traditional banks and pension companies dominate the Nordic saving markets, Nordnet did and still does play the role, alongside a few competitors, of the challenger. Right from the start the bank offered customers the opportunity to trade and invest over the internet and still, as they frame it themselves, "the core focus is still to make trading easy and accessible for anyone".

Nordnet thus uses its online communication and rhetoric around this as a way of positioning in the strategic sense. It positions itself by its products/services; not having traditional physical bank offices, but only being present online, that is, it positions itself in the market sense. In the beginning, the company described itself as explicitly talked about itself as doing "new banking" in comparison to "old banking". It also uses its online presence and its talk around this as a core brand positioning. This means that Nordnet uses its online presence to position both the products and the brand simultaneously, seemingly doing a synergy between these two (Urde *et al.*, 2013). Being online is simply who they are – it is part of the organisational identity – and the company's product and brand core rhetoric have been consistent during these ten years (Urde, 2016).

Nordnet's online strategy also includes communication. Its use of online channels and platforms make the bank function as a news producer and provider independent from traditional media outlets. Like many other organisations, the bank is taking advantage of the many possibilities to be a content producer and distributor online. They use multiple communication channels and platforms for reaching out to current as well as potential clients: the website has a special section named "social media" and there the visitor can find several Twitter accounts, its Facebook group, YouTube channel, and Instagram account. In addition they produce two different podcasts: #sparpodden (saving podcast) and #slowtofast as well as posting content on their blog, Nordnetbloggen (where also partners and customers are invited to contribute sometimes). Nordnet has also developed an online investor forum and network, called Shareville, with over 80,000 investors' portfolios to follow and learn from (www.shareville.se).

The Twittering CEO

Nyberg's trajectory on Twitter began on 10 April 2013, when he tweeted "After pressure from colleagues @JanNordnet [Jan Dinkelspiel, at the time innovation manager] and @gunthermarder [Günther Mårder, at the time savings economist], I now connect to #CEOtwitter. Who will be the next CEO?" Nyberg argued that a digital company, such as Nordnet, needs a "digital CEO" – using Twitter as one tool for being and marketing himself as digital.

The content of Nyberg's tweets can be categorised into three broad themes: marketing Nordnet content, meetings that Nyberg attends himself, and sharing content on leadership and the importance of diversity.

Marketing and circulating Nordnet content published elsewhere

Nyberg's use of Twitter appears to be just one more channel for circulating corporate information. A majority of the total tweets are based on Nordnet content already published by someone else on the website or elsewhere. The list of possible activities can be made long since Nordnet is very active and publishes content in many different communication channels (making it possible to also share content easily between these channels): e.g. Nordnetbloggen (the Nordnet blog), Sparpodden (podcast on saving issues), Videoblog, quarterly reports and other corporate information online, Nordnet web course and Nordnet

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commercials (videos on Youtube). Also, Nyberg frequently forwards advertisements for recruitments from the company's human resources department.

The many different communication activities are feeding one another – a new episode of the podcast "Sparpodden" (Savings podcast) can be marketed in a blog post on the Nordnet blog, and has also been highlighted in a post on Facebook as well as in a tweet on Twitter. Thereafter it can be spread in more rounds in the same channels as, for example, the CEO re-tweets the information. Whereas, for example, the podcast is dependent on at least partly new content and new themes to discuss in each episode, Twitter as a communication channel appears to be more of simply an intermediary "shuffling" or marketing already produced and packaged content onto followers on yet one more platform.

Status updates from meetings

Over the studied period of time (from the first tweet in April, 2013, until 31 December, 2015), Nyberg takes an increasingly active role on Twitter in terms of posting status updates from various meetings, conferences, and seminars. The tweets are most often accompanied by a photo – a selfie – of the CEO showing him being physically present at the meeting point. This can be anything from attending a meeting or conference to participating in a panel debate or giving a speech. For example, when visiting the European Parliament in Brussels in December 2015, Nyberg was tweeting from the meeting with the Committee on Economic and Monetary Affairs, from a meeting with Sweden in the EU and with the ambassador Anders Ahnlid and was also mentioning more private meetings with specific key persons.

Leadership and diversity management

These tweets and re-tweets are mainly a mix between announcing events and presentations about leadership and/or diversity issues in which Nyberg participates (can be both tweets by Nyberg announcing his presence at a conference or a meeting and re-tweets by other people listening to Nyberg) and sharing knowledge and research on how to be a great leader and the importance of diversity. For example, Nyberg seems to only perfunctorily re-tweet weekly posts on leadership from the Harvard Business Review on leadership. The overall image that emerges from these particular tweets and re-tweets is that Nyberg appears to be a CEO with a commitment to equality and diversity and who is happy to participate in discussion on such topics.

The overall narrative of the CEO tweets

Based on our content analysis, we have developed three key characteristics of Nyberg's narrative rhetoric on Twitter. The characteristics provide insights on CEO communication in social media that challenge much of the established notions of personalised messages and interactions: limited scope of actors and content – the internal and local Nordnet sphere, formal tone in the tweets – corporate information and presentation, and few examples of dialogue – limited number of voices outside of Nordnet.

Limited scope of actors and content – the internal and local Nordnet sphere

In total, 298 of the tweets are written by Nyberg himself, which means that someone else has originally written the majority of what appears on his Twitter account. Most of the re-tweets are however also from people within Nordnet. Overall, Nyberg's account and Twitter trajectory is surprisingly internal. The former savings economist Günther Mårder together with the manager for Sweden, Eva Truin (@EvaNordnet), and country manager for Norway, Anders Skar (@AndersNordnet), are the Twitter users that Nyberg re-tweets most frequently. Most often these re-tweets are to inform about an up-coming event, a new episode of Sparpodden, or a post on the Nordnet blog. Much of the information on Nyberg's

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Twitter account is thus part of the broader information flow produced by people at Nordnet and circulated via the many different communication platforms and channels of the company.

The open and very unlimited sphere of Twitter suggests a plurality of actors and possibilities to "meet" and engage in dialogue with Twitter users from around the world. In the case of Nordnet, consumers, potential consumers and other stakeholder groups such as journalists, financial analysts, and representatives of interest groups and associations related to the banking industry would be possible target groups to meet and "mingle with" online. However, the very limited sphere of people that Nyberg chooses to pay attention to, by, for example, re-tweeting or by mentioning in his own tweets creates instead an internal atmosphere that very much excludes other people than those that Nyberg already has an established contact with (his own employees).

People outside of Nordnet are less frequently mentioned or re-tweeted by Nyberg. @veckansaffarer (business weekly Veckans Affärer) was mentioned ten times and mainly because the weekly nominated Nordnet as the most successful company on the stock exchange and because Nyberg had lunch together then the editor in chief, Ulf Skarin.

Formal tone in the tweets – corporate presentation and information

The limited number of tweets written by Nyberg himself are rather formal in tone, meaning that more personal attributes and opinions are left out of the discussions. As announcing that he is participating in an event or meeting is one dominating theme in Nyberg's original tweets these are often very informative, indicating where he is and accompanied by a selfie, a photo of Nyberg himself. The impression of a formal, corporate tone in the tweets is enhanced by the fact that the majority of the content is made up of re-tweets of various Nordnet activities. Nyberg's Twitter account is very much situated in the online corporate information web of Nordnet in which the same information (e.g. about a new podcast episode, a new post on the blog, or an advertisement for recruitments) is circulated in between the various channels. Nyberg's account thus "one more channel" of corporate information rather than a personal CEO voice sharing his views and visions.

Few examples of dialogues – limited number of voices outside Nordet

A basic fundament of social media such as Twitter is the possibility to interact with other users. However, only 90 tweets/re-tweets of the total 981 contain some kind of dialogue between Nyberg and someone else. In these cases – where dialogue exists – it is most often a client or a potential client on Twitter asking a question that has to do with services or Nordnet products. Most often Nyberg answers by directing the person to someone else within the company. Even though the number of people engaging in dialogue with Nyberg seems to be rather low, it nonetheless shows that Twitter is an open area for anyone to join in the conversation. Simply by being on Twitter, Nyberg makes a clear statement that he is "available" for conversations. Private people asking questions over, for example, e-mail is probably much easier to disregard than if these questions are posed online in the public sphere for anybody to see. Answers might also be helpful for more people than for just the person asking.

Conclusions and discussion

A common understanding of social media is that it opens up for personal communication and encourages engaging in dialogue. In literature on corporate communication and digitisation, organisational crises have been in the centre of attention due to the growing number of examples from the corporate world when Twitter has been used to manage and deconstruct critical voices and rebuild trust and reputation. The analysis proves that the

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role of social media such as Twitter must be understood more broadly and as playing multiple roles and changing over time. The data set of CEO Nyberg's Twitter feed over more than two and a half years without any major events or crises for Nordnet paints a picture of a rather non-personal CEO with few friends and with limited ideas and issues to discuss to share online.

The expectations of new media – not least social media such as Twitter – are enormous and often carry aspirations far beyond serving and helping customer needs, such as democratisation of the public dialogue and making space for previously less heard voices. The character of the digital narrative and the rhetoric used by the CEO of Nordnet – a forerunner in digitising the Swedish banking sector and a CEO who presents himself as being "digital" – reminds us that we need to be more humble towards what social media communication can provide us with, at least in a short-term perspective. At the same time – the mere fact that Nyberg is "out there", situating himself into the context of social media, is a significant change: being on Twitter sends a message in itself of being open and available for dialogue with the broader public.

Also, as suggested by Tunby Gulbrandsen and Nörholm Just (2013), Nyberg's narrative is heavily dependent on the corporate, professional meta-narrative of the entire bank, Nordnet. This is interestingly similar to the problems discussed in organisational rhetoric where it is identified that an individual can be a part of, but also apart from, the organisational voice (cf. Boyd and Waymer, 2011). The many re-tweets and the large proportion of content produced and provided directly from the bank itself suggest that Nyberg's Twitter feed is just one additional channel that needs to be filled with content – the Nordnet content is handy as it is already provided, ready to be used and must be spread.

In Latin, Ciceronian rhetoric, the figure of *evidentia* is highlighted, by the use of detailed description by the speaker (Vasaly, 1993, p. 90). The CEO in this case study intensifies over the studied time period the number and frequency of tweets showing that he is present at various meetings and events. He also starts taking "selfies", which prove his presence. This can be seen as a, not very subtle, way of using *evidentia*; Nyberg was here. Perhaps the role of the rhetorical figure *evidentia* can be interpreted as one description of this CEO's engagement on Twitter: a way to offer detailed proof that he is there: in the discussion of diversity; in the latest theories on management and leadership strategies of Harvard Business Review; at meetings and events; in the digital world of Nordnet; and as a leader telling stories through social media.

One key concept in classical rhetorical analysis is the rhetorical situation. This includes elements such as *exigence*; what happens or does not happen, what the rhetorical act is a response to. Further, also the rhetor, the method, and intended audience. One of the most important parts is *kairos*, the timing of the rhetorical speech act taking place (Bitzer, 1968). As stated earlier, this study focuses on everyday life rather than the more investigated situations of organisational crises. This means that it is not one single and specific event that is being communicated; in relation to rather it is an on-going, constantly produced communication about many issues, events, and people. The *exigence* taking place is not something extraordinary, rather managerial everyday activities. Still, Nyberg feels compelled to speak out. He is giving an answer, without always having a question. The context of Twitter provides the possibility of having an interaction with employees, media, and customers. But the on-going narrative on Nyberg's Twitter account appears rather isolated and in-house Nordnet. Nonetheless, by being present online, he is available if a larger crisis or event were to take place. Nyberg's presence can therefore also be interpreted as just a way to be "in place" – to be part of the communication channel with a group of followers – if and when this is needed.

It is fair to ask why this takes place. Why is a CEO engaged on Twitter? One could argue that it all boils down to the question of ethos, the character strategy for persuasion,

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stemming from the thoughts of Aristotle (1991). As Nyberg is expected to appear and CEO of an online bank, it is expected of Nyberg to also appear and be active online. As can be seen in his first tweet, this is what happened. Further, what is taking place on the CEO's Twitter feed is re-tweets, status updates on what he is doing and with whom. His re-tweets spread already rather formally packaged Nordnet content, but also, even though to a much lesser extent, Harvard Business Review content and issues regarding gender and diversity. We can picture Nyberg on Twitter as a rhetor communicating ethos with up-to-date theory of management and leadership and with the use of appropriate and "modern" value-driven areas such as gender and diversity.

This is one case study, not a generalised truth. But it is a case study that presents a picture that diverges from what we normally see and hear about. In many of the examples in both popular management and scholarly research, social media are described as personal, fun, important, and as something that makes a difference. The present case proves that there are many possible roles for social media to play. As the use of narratives as a rhetorical competence has been put forward as an important part of leadership skills and duties, the role of narrative skills has been enhanced by the opportunities that come with social media. In particular the opportunity to communicate in the public arena without the filer of media has created expectations on leaders and others to present their own ideas and images – to become storytellers in a more literal sense. And yes, participating in social media gives leaders opportunities to be personal, to be bold, and to be interactive, but the present case study illustrates and reminds us that it does not automatically mean that they will be.

The case study contributes to existing research on corporate and leadership narratives as a part of broader questions concerning how the voice of the organisation are constructed (see Boje, 1991; Czarniawska, 1997; Backer, 2008; Boyd and Waymer, 2011; Auvinen *et al.*, 2013) and in particular how dynamics and scope change as the narration is undertaken online (Couldry, 2008; Alghawi *et al.*, 2014; Jameson, 2014; Lundby, 2008a, b, 2014). The conception that communication online tends to be fragmented, as it often includes a multiplicity of actors and short but many pieces of information, and that this in turn would allow for a more democratic communication climate and foster oppositional viewpoints as well as a more nuanced content has been challenged (e.g. Grafström and Windell, 2012; Larsson, 2013). Our case study illustrates that leadership narratives in social media tend to contribute to the overall narrative already being told by the company: the CEO tweets in this study to a large extent give the reader more of the same (but through a different channel).

The present case also contributes to research on positioning (Urde *et al.*, 2013), by showing how a company can use narratives to position itself, both its products and its brand. The narratives of the leader might not add or develop the use of communication as part of the position strategy, but can still have the function of strengthening and clarify the role of the company and its products and brand. The storytelling of the CEO him/herself brings legitimacy to the overall corporate narratives. Further, the analysis in this paper contributes to the area of rhetoric of organisations and leadership (Boyd and Waymer, 2011; Bonet, 2014). Our example illustrates that the classical rhetorical analytical concepts, such as Kairos, can also clarify the understanding of modern digitised communication.

The "more of the same" argument – that CEO presence on Twitter just adds more of the same content already out there – discussed here urges us to ask: It is worth doing? If the use of social media by CEOs does not necessarily develop the corporate narrative already in place and lacks possibilities to extend networks and create relationship with stakeholders – what role does the Twitter presence play? In what way does it contribute and play a role in the creation of corporate identity? The everyday communication online – does it then really matter? This finding calls for further research around the area of social media as a communication channel for corporations. The field of narrative leadership and literature on how leaders use social media as well as how they need to manage a changing media

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landscape would very much gain from in-depth empirical investigations to unwrap and build knowledge on the specific dynamics of online communication. Such empirical studies can function as bridges between different streams of literature within the field and help to build more robust and fine-grained understanding of what to expect from the social media presence of CEOs.

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